

The job is finding a photo you still picture — not a better search box

People start with a fragment of memory. Success is opening the photo they meant. Faster indexing or a smarter keyword rank is a different product.

North-star metric • OUR BET

Successful vague-memory retrieval rate = users who find the intended photo on a vague-memory task ÷ users who start a search with incomplete memory.

Out of scope

Search latency, ranking of exact keywords, and "make search feel faster."

- METRIC DECOMPOSITION

That number only moves if Photos understands the clue the person still has

One bet. The other steps stay healthy; they are not a second product.

Formulate

Turn incomplete memory into a starting clue.

Understand · OUR BET

Accept vibe, object, or episode — not a date first.

Retrieve

Target in the first grouped set.

Recognize

The person opens the intended photo.

Refine

"More like this" or "not this trip."

Sub-metrics: formulation rate, clue-understanding rate, candidate coverage, recognition rate, refinement success, workaround-scroll rate, known-item control success.

Bet labeled in words, not by colour alone

Public voice becomes ranked retrieval problems — not a sentiment dashboard

1

Listen

Public photo talk: stores, forums, community posts.

2

Keep

Stories about a failed find. Drop storage and star-rating noise.

3

Group

Themes that share at least two real quotes.

4

Score

Impact, feasibility, and how often it appears.

5

Drop

"Search is slow" is not this job.

Research covered: photo kinds people struggle to find, remembered vs forgotten cues, search breakdowns, workarounds, result quality, refinement behavior, and segment differences.

• OPPORTUNITY RANKING

Place without a name is the first problem we will solve.
Generic search we refused.

People remember how a café felt and have forgotten the town.

Opportunity	Impact	Feasibility	Frequency	Node
Place-vibe without name	High	High	High	Understand
Generic search latency	High	High	High	Out of scope
Object + episode	Medium	Medium	Medium	Understand

Top opportunity: place-vibe without a name · Metric: understand · Audience: trip rememberers

Six in-segment interviews validated the hypothesis before we built

Method

Google Form G1–G9. 30 min protocol. Reconstruct one failed find until memory is specific.

Screeners

Photos ≥ 12 months. Library large enough that scrolling is not default. Can recall at least one remembered-but-unfound photo. Matches S2.

Protocol

Recover: retrieval task, remembered cues, forgotten cues, query typed, Photos response, workaround, recognizability, next attempt.

Form: <https://forms.gle/wvQ3pQVQLhxMDFTm9> · Responses: 6 submitted, 6 in-segment S2 · Known-item excluded

• WHAT THE RESEARCH CONFIRMED

Place-vibe confirmed. Forgotten date/album confirmed.
Generic search not supported.

Discovery theme	vs form	Node	Note
Place-vibe without name	Confirmed	Understand	G4/G5 trip/place vibe; G6 place-felt/trip; G8 take vibe or trip without town
Forgotten date/album	Confirmed	Formulate	Forgotten cue confirmed. Product bet stays understand, not formulate
Timeline scroll workaround	Confirmed	Refine	G9: scroll, ask a person, another app, or still unfound
Generic search latency	Not supported	Out of scope	Form asks memory, not speed. Out of brief scope

- THE PROBLEM

People remember how a place felt on a trip and have forgotten the date, album, and town name

Target segment

S2 Trip/event rememberer.
Large library. Remembers trip by
vibe (café, lights, boat).
Forgotten date, album, town
name.

Retrieval scenario

The café I cannot date — a trip
photo the person can still
picture when capture day and
place name are gone.

Product outcome · OUR BET

Understand — the product
accepts vibe, object, episode,
and fuzzy time. Exactly one
node.

Root cause: Search cannot take the clue they still have even though the photo is in the library. Workarounds: scroll, ask a person, another app, still unfound. Business value: library people cannot re-enter becomes write-only backup.

- REMEMBER

Remember puts intelligence at the moment of understanding: a vibe in, a trip group out

1

Offer a fragment

Type or speak what is left. Never a date first.

2

See a trip group

Photos groups the trip and says why this set.

3

Confirm or steer

Open the photo, or say "not this trip."

Keyword Search stays the control. Remember is a different path — not a second search box. Intelligence at understand (place-vibe language → grouped candidates).

- RETURN TEST RESULTS

Three return sessions found the café, the trip, and the gig. Keep grouping by trip.

What worked (n=3)

t01: keyword miss, Remember success on task-go-a-cafe.

t02: keyword miss, Remember success on task-go-a-trip.

t03: keyword miss, Remember success on task-concert-lights.

What to change next · OUR BET

Keep trip grouping with near-miss Europe café. Place-name clue still has to group by trip. Keep vibe-language grouping (lights/gig) and never ask venue or date first.

Three trip rememberers completed retrieval tasks, tried the keyword baseline, and identified a next change. Prototype library — not their Google Photos account.

- **SUCCESS METRICS & RISKS**

We will know it worked when more of these searches end on the right photo

Leading metrics

- Clue submitted as memory language (without date first)
- MemoryQuery holds the locked cue type (placeVibe, object, episode, fuzzy time)
- Target in the first grouped set
- Target opened from a group
- Success after refine

Risks & mitigations

- Read as "better search" → composer asks for fragment, not "Search your photos"
- Model invents date/town → ground MemoryQuery in typed tokens; strip assistantText matching date/GPS patterns
- Learned café task success → use a respondent's own task when the original photo can be used

Guardrails: control date, task still succeeds in Search; hallucinated EXIF rate stays at zero. Metrics are prototype signals, not Google production telemetry.